

Postpartum - Headache - Female (Adult)

Algorithm 1425 | Adult (18 years and older) | Gender at birth: Female

Definition

- Postpartum headache assessment for a person who has given birth within the last year. Pre-eclampsia is especially relevant in the first days or weeks after birth; other pregnancy-related complications can occur later.
- Adult patient.
- Female.

Initial assessment

1. [DURATION] How many days/weeks since delivery?
2. [PAIN_SCALE] How severe is the headache, 0-10?
3. [YES_NO] Any vision changes, swelling, or pain below the ribs?
4. [YES_NO] If the patient is under 18, can they speak privately now, and do they say they feel safe with the accompanying adult?

Triage and redirect questions

1. *Redirect* → *Headache*

Is this a non-postpartum headache presentation without recent childbirth?

A headache not occurring in the postpartum period belongs in the Headache pathway.

1. *Disposition level 100*

Is there a severe headache that doesn't go away with simple painkillers, vision problems (blurred vision or flashing lights), pain below the ribs, sudden swelling of the face/hands/feet, feeling very unwell, persistent heartburn unresponsive to medication, or vomiting?

NHS.UK guidance lists these as pre-eclampsia warning signs that can appear in the days or weeks after birth and always need immediate evaluation.

1. *Disposition level 70*

Is there a new or persistent postpartum headache without the emergency features above?

A new or persistent headache after birth requires clinical assessment because remote questioning alone cannot exclude a hypertensive, neurological, anaesthetic-related, or infectious cause.

Advice

Emergency postpartum pre-eclampsia precautions

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 now. Do not drive yourself. Tell the call handler that the patient gave birth recently. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.
- Call Back If: worsening headache; vision changes worsen.

Prompt postpartum headache review

- Arrange prompt clinical assessment through the locally approved Qatar maternity pathway; the exact non-emergency destination requires local approval. Seek emergency help on 999 if the headache becomes severe or vision change, fainting, seizure, breathing difficulty, chest pain, severe upper abdominal pain, or marked swelling develops.
- Call Back If: headache becomes severe; vision changes or swelling develop.

First aid

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 now. Do not drive yourself. Tell the call handler that the patient gave birth recently. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.

References

- NHS.UK, "Pre-eclampsia", <https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/pre-eclampsia/> (page last reviewed 23 March 2026) - explicitly covers postpartum onset
- CDC Hear Her, urgent maternal warning signs during pregnancy or within one year after pregnancy, <https://www.cdc.gov/hearher/>

Provenance

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